

FASTEN SEAT BELTS

The discovery of half-a-century-old airfields and their planned modernisation has sparked off hopes for the state's economic revival and is expected to give a fillip to its tourism sector

■ By Farzand Ahmed

The popular perception of Bihar is of a state where snails move faster than trains and a 100 metre of bitumen roads without potholes is considered an expressway. But the state's transportation industry can take heart if recent "discoveries" are anything to go by. The state Government recently "stumbled" upon 21 airfields, most of them over half-a-century-old that now lie abandoned. Some of these were built during World War II and the Chinese aggression of 1962. The euphoria created by this "discovery" is unmatched and has prompted both Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and his deputy Sushil Modi to say that these have sparked off hopes for the state's economic revival.

The Government is so excited that it asked the officials to draw up plans to revive these airfields and link them

to Patna and metros like Kolkata, Mumbai and Delhi. It also wants to introduce an air taxi network to connect the Buddhist circuits of Patna, Rajgir, Bodhgaya, Vaishali (Hajipur), Sarnath (Varanasi) and Kushinagar. The Government has plans to use the airfield to review and monitor development activities too. Of the 21 airfields, three are under the control of the Indian Air Force, five have *kachcha* runways, nine have been classified as "abandoned", while the rest, though have metalled runways, are without any navigational, meteorological or technical support. Most airfields have no boundary walls, which means that incoming aircraft—as and when that happens—will have to avoid the ubiquitous cows and buffaloes. But Captain Deepak Kumar Singh, joint director,

NO TAKE-OFF: Goats and buffaloes routinely patrol the Bhagalpur airport runway

Bihar Civil Aviation Department, says the Government has agreed to convert all *kachcha* runways into metalled ones and fence the airstrips.

Not long ago, the then Union Minister for Civil Aviation, Syed Shahnawaz Hussain had helped develop the airport at Bodhgaya into an international one. The airport, which now attracts lakhs of Buddhists annually, is bigger than the one in Patna and is directly linked with Sri Lanka, Singapore and Thailand. Other airfields at Bhagalpur, Muzaffarpur and Begusarai continue to rot though Hussain is using his rapport with the current Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel to transform the Bhagalpur strip into an airport capable of handling 70-seater ATR. Situated midway between Kolkata and Patna, it makes sense to develop the airport, which could then be linked with other smaller airfields in the region. Besides, Hussain wants

